

SAMUEL MORRISON'S JOURNEY

A TRUE FAMILY JOURNEY

Samuel Morrison's Journey

From County Cavan to the Canadian Forest

Ireland to Lower Canada, 1835

Retold for readers ages 8 to 11

A NOTE FROM GRANDMA BORSTAD'S FAMILY

This is a true story originally written by Rose Boyd, a sister of one of Grandma Borstad's grandmothers. It is about her great-great-great-grandfather Samuel Morrison and the family journey from Ireland to Canada. Grandpa Borstad has used ChatGPT to shorten the story and to make the illustrations.

Meet the Morrison Family

Samuel Morrison: father and farmer; Grandma Borstad's great-great-great-grandfather

Elizabeth Morrison: mother, skilled lace maker, and keeper of the home in Ireland

James Morrison: the oldest son, a cheerful cook during the first summer in Canada

Hugh Morrison: the next son, who crossed the Atlantic with Samuel and James

Eliza Jane Morrison: daughter who remained in Ireland with Elizabeth

William Morrison: the youngest child, who also remained in Ireland

A note before you begin: This story is based on a family narrative. It preserves the people, journey, remembered dialogue, and folklore while using clearer language for young readers. Short History Windows add background from Library and Archives Canada.

CHAPTER 1

Stone Fields and Linen Threads

Around 1830, the Morrison family lived in County Cavan, Ireland. Samuel and Elizabeth shared their home with four children: James, the oldest; Hugh; Eliza Jane; and William, the youngest.

Cavan was green and beautiful, but the Morrison family's small piece of land was rocky. Farming meant bending, lifting, digging, and working around stones. Most jobs had to be done by hand. By evening, everyone was ready to rest.

Elizabeth knew many useful skills. She could spin fibre, knit, crochet, and make lace. Fine handwork was not only beautiful. It could be sold or traded, and every coin mattered to a family planning a difficult journey.

When work was finished, neighbours sometimes visited. They sang, danced, and told stories. Those evenings brought laughter to lives filled with hard labour.

**HISTORY WINDOW: LINEN AND HANDWORK**

For generations, spinning, weaving, lacework, and other textile skills helped many Irish households earn money. Much of this work was done at home before factory production became widespread.

CHAPTER 2

Leprechauns, Ghosts, and Midnight Stairs

Irish folklore filled the Morrison children's imaginations. A white cloud might look like a tiny leprechaun sitting on its edge and playing a harp. A small bare patch in the grass might become proof that the 'little people' had visited during the night.

Ghost stories were even more exciting. One family tale told of a girl named Fanny who had died after an accident. According to the story, footsteps sounded on the stairs every night at midnight. Then a white figure appeared beside Fanny's old bed.

Was it really a ghost? The old story does not prove that it was. Folklore often mixes memory, imagination, fear, and fun. What it does show is how families entertained one another before radio, television, or electric light.



CHAPTER 3

A Plan for a New Land

Samuel and Elizabeth began to think about Canada. They had heard that land could be obtained in Lower Canada, as Quebec was then called. The journey would be long, and starting a farm in the forest would be dangerous work. Still, they hoped Canada might offer their children a better future.

The family saved every penny it could. Elizabeth crocheted lace to sell. Butter from the family cow was taken to a shop and traded for flour, tea, and sometimes a little sugar. Sugar and butter were luxuries, so the family often ate potatoes with buttermilk.

Their plan was careful but painful. Samuel would travel first with James and Hugh. Elizabeth would remain in Ireland with Eliza Jane and young William. Once the three travellers had cleared land and built a safe home, the others could follow.

No one could send a quick message across the ocean. A letter might take weeks or months. When the family said goodbye in the spring of 1835, nobody could be certain when they would meet again.



CHAPTER 4

Across the Atlantic

The three Morrisons crossed the Atlantic in a sailing ship. Wind, rather than an engine, drove the vessel. Samuel was seasick during the first days, but James and Hugh kept their appetites and treated the voyage as an adventure.

The ship rolled through grey waves. Days passed with water in every direction. Then a cry travelled across the deck: land had been sighted. Halifax appeared ahead.

Reaching Halifax did not end the journey. Samuel, James, and Hugh still had to travel by water to Montreal and then go inland toward Wentworth, about eighty miles northwest of the city. Canada already seemed enormous.

**HISTORY WINDOW: THE OCEAN CROSSING**

Sailing ships still carried Irish emigrants across the Atlantic in the mid-1800s. Library and Archives Canada notes that a sailing voyage could take six to eight weeks in good conditions.

CHAPTER 5

Montreal and the Road Ahead

After many more days of travel, the three reached Montreal tired and worn. Samuel wondered whether leaving Ireland had been the right choice. James and Hugh were homesick too.

But turning back would not build the home they had promised Elizabeth, Eliza Jane, and William. Samuel was strong, ambitious, and used to hard work. He decided they would continue.

They found a man with horses and a wagon who could carry them part of the way. When the wagon could go no farther, nearly forty miles of the journey remained. The three travellers lifted their belongings and food and began to walk.

**HISTORY WINDOW: ARRIVING BEFORE 1865**

Canada did not require shipping companies to keep comprehensive passenger lists until 1865. That is why family stories, letters, church records, and scattered archival lists are especially important for earlier arrivals.

CHAPTER 6

Forty Miles on Foot

The trail ran between tall trees. Blazes cut into trunks showed the route where there were no road signs. Fallen trees sometimes blocked the way, and the Morrisons used an axe to clear a path.

James and Hugh were growing boys, and they were often hungry. Still, their food had to be rationed. They could not know when they would find more supplies.

Near their destination, the forest also offered food. Deer, moose, and partridge were plentiful. Hunting could provide meat, although it required skill and care. At last the three reached the land where they intended to begin again.

**HISTORY WINDOW: HELP IN MONTREAL**

The Montreal Emigrant Society was founded in 1831. It provided transportation and supplies to many newcomers travelling from Montreal toward settlements in Lower and Upper Canada.

CHAPTER 7

The First Rough Shelter

Samuel filed a claim for one hundred acres in 1835. Before the family could build a proper log house, the three newcomers needed immediate shelter.

They gathered dry cedar logs for the lower walls. Poles supported a roof covered with pieces of sod. The shelter did not keep out much rain, so everyone hoped for clear weather.

Their beds were made from poles driven into the ground and crossed with more poles. About two feet of springy cedar boughs formed each mattress. A blanket went underneath and another over top. It was simple, but after a day of walking and chopping, it probably felt comfortable.

Outside, they built a fireplace from stones. James often did the cooking. When a meal was ready, he called cheerfully, 'Come and get it - fit for a king!' His joke helped push away some of the loneliness.



CHAPTER 8

Night Sounds in the Forest

Darkness in the Canadian forest sounded very different from night in Cavan. Bears and other animals moved beyond the firelight. Wolves howled. Even an owl calling 'Who? Who?' could make the boys' hearts beat faster.

Fear did not mean they were weak. They were in an unfamiliar wilderness, separated from the rest of their family by an ocean. Courage meant continuing even while they were afraid.

Each morning brought more work. Great maples, cedars, and birches stood across the land. With no nearby sawmill, the Morrisons burned many felled trees. The largest stumps were left to rot, and the first crops would have to grow around them.



CHAPTER 9

Building Toward Tomorrow

Day after day, Samuel, James, and Hugh cut logs with an axe and crosscut saw. They planned a one-storey house. Stones placed at intervals formed a simple foundation, and the first round of logs was laid on top.

Then an accident slowed the work. James stumbled, and a log struck his leg. He had to rest while it healed. With one worker unable to help, every task took longer.

Samuel was more than six feet tall and very strong, but the labour exhausted him too. At night, his head had hardly touched the cedar-bough pillow before he fell asleep.



The story pauses here, with the first walls rising from the clearing. The house was more than logs and stones. It was a promise to Elizabeth, Eliza Jane, and William: a place where the family could begin its Canadian life together. I will upload more chapters soon.

HISTORY WINDOW: A FAMILY STORY

This retelling follows a family narrative. Details such as dialogue, feelings, and remembered folklore belong to that tradition. The broader immigration notes come from Library and Archives Canada.

A Few Words to Know

Blaze: a mark cut into a tree to show a trail

Crosscut Saw: a long saw designed to cut across the grain of wood

Homestead: land where a settler builds a home and farm

Lower Canada: the British colony that included much of present-day southern Quebec

Ration: to divide a limited supply so it lasts longer

Sources and Story Notes

- Primary story source: James Morrison 1809-1875 narrative, a five-page family account.
- Library and Archives Canada, Immigration records from the British and French regimes.
- Library and Archives Canada, Immigrants before 1865.
- Library and Archives Canada, Immigrants sponsored by the Montreal Emigrant Society, 1832.
- Library and Archives Canada, The Shamrock and the Fleur-de-Lys (Irish immigration to Quebec).